

# 1998 NBA Finals

The **1998 NBA Finals** was the championship series of the National Basketball Association's (NBA) 1997–98 season, and the conclusion of the season's playoffs. The two-time defending NBA champion and Eastern Conference champion Chicago Bulls played against the Western Conference champion Utah Jazz, with the Jazz holding home-court advantage for the first 2 games in Salt Lake City. In a repeat of the previous year's Finals, the Bulls defeated the Jazz in six games for their third consecutive NBA title and their sixth in eight seasons.

Michael Jordan was voted the NBA Finals MVP of the series (he also had won the award the last five times the Bulls won the Finals: 1991, 1992, 1993, 1996, and 1997). This would be his sixth NBA championship and sixth Finals MVP award in six full basketball seasons. This would be his final season of winning the NBA championship and Finals MVP. Until 2021 this would be the last finals not to feature a team from California, Florida, or Texas.

The 1998 Finals garnered the highest Nielsen TV ratings in NBA history at 18.7, and even surpassed the Nielsen ratings for the 1998 World Series, marking the first time the NBA had a higher rating in its championship round than of Major League Baseball's championship round.

The Bulls headed into the series as the underdogs. Bulls' small forward Scottie Pippen stated, "It's a different feeling. We've never been in this situation where we've sort of been written off. It's a great feeling being the underdog because you want to go out now and prove everybody wrong."<sup>[1]</sup>

As of 2026, this is Chicago's most recent championship and Finals appearance, and they currently hold the longest Finals appearance drought of the Central Division teams.

## Background

Entering the 1997–98, this was widely expected to be the last season of the Chicago Bulls core of Michael Jordan, Scottie Pippen, Dennis Rodman, and Phil Jackson. In training camp, Phil Jackson wrote on the chalk board and named the season "The Last Dance".<sup>[2]</sup>

The series marked the first time since 1989 that the same two teams met in the Finals in consecutive years. The Jazz earned the league's best record by virtue of sweeping the two-game regular season series with the Bulls despite both teams finishing at 62 wins. In the playoffs, the Jazz were pushed to the brink by the Houston Rockets before winning Game 5 in Utah, and then overcame Rookie of the Year Tim Duncan and the San Antonio Spurs 4–1. They then swept the Los Angeles Lakers in the Western Conference finals. The Bulls swept the New Jersey Nets and then took out the Charlotte Hornets in five, but it took seven games to overcome the Indiana Pacers in the Eastern Conference Finals.

### 1998 NBA Finals



| Team                  | Coach                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | Wins |
|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| <u>Chicago Bulls</u>  | <u>Phil Jackson</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | 4    |
| <u>Utah Jazz</u>      | <u>Jerry Sloan</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | 2    |
| <b>Dates</b>          | June 3–14                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |      |
| <b>MVP</b>            | <u>Michael Jordan</u><br>( <u>Chicago Bulls</u> )                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |      |
| <b>Hall of Famers</b> | <b>Bulls:</b><br><u>Michael Jordan</u> (2009)<br><u>Toni Kukoc</u> (2021)<br><u>Scottie Pippen</u> (2010)<br><u>Dennis Rodman</u> (2011)<br><b>Jazz:</b><br><u>Karl Malone</u> (2010)<br><u>John Stockton</u> (2009)<br><b>Coaches:</b><br><u>Phil Jackson</u> (2007)<br><u>Jerry Sloan</u> (2009)<br><u>Tex Winter</u> (2011)<br><b>Officials:</b><br><u>Dick Bavetta</u> (2015)<br><u>Danny Crawford</u> (2025)<br><u>Hugh Evans</u> (2022) |      |
| <b>Eastern finals</b> | <u>Bulls</u> defeated <u>Pacers</u> , 4–3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |      |
| <b>Western finals</b> | <u>Jazz</u> defeated <u>Lakers</u> , 4–0                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |      |

## Road to the Finals

| Utah Jazz (Western Conference champion)          |                                 |    |    |      |    | Chicago Bulls (Eastern Conference champion)       |                                                 |    |    |      |    |
|--------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|----|----|------|----|---------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|----|----|------|----|
| #                                                | Western Conference              |    |    |      |    | #                                                 | Eastern Conference                              |    |    |      |    |
|                                                  | Team                            | W  | L  | PCT  | GB |                                                   | Team                                            | W  | L  | PCT  | GB |
| 1                                                | <u>z-Utah Jazz</u>              | 62 | 20 | .756 | –  | 1                                                 | <u>c-Chicago Bulls</u>                          | 62 | 20 | .756 | –  |
| 2                                                | <u>y-Seattle SuperSonics</u>    | 61 | 21 | .744 | 1  | 2                                                 | <u>y-Miami Heat</u>                             | 55 | 27 | .671 | 7  |
| 3                                                | <u>x-Los Angeles Lakers</u>     | 61 | 21 | .744 | 1  | 3                                                 | <u>x-Indiana Pacers</u>                         | 58 | 24 | .707 | 4  |
| 4                                                | <u>x-Phoenix Suns</u>           | 56 | 26 | .683 | 6  | 4                                                 | <u>x-Charlotte Hornets</u>                      | 51 | 31 | .622 | 11 |
| 5                                                | <u>x-San Antonio Spurs</u>      | 56 | 26 | .683 | 6  | 5                                                 | <u>x-Atlanta Hawks</u>                          | 50 | 32 | .610 | 12 |
| 6                                                | <u>x-Portland Trail Blazers</u> | 46 | 36 | .561 | 16 | 6                                                 | <u>x-Cleveland Cavaliers</u>                    | 47 | 35 | .573 | 15 |
| 7                                                | <u>x-Minnesota Timberwolves</u> | 45 | 37 | .549 | 17 | 7                                                 | <u>x-New York Knicks</u>                        | 43 | 39 | .524 | 19 |
| 8                                                | <u>x-Houston Rockets</u>        | 41 | 41 | .500 | 21 | 8                                                 | <u>x-New Jersey Nets</u>                        | 43 | 39 | .524 | 19 |
|                                                  |                                 |    |    |      |    |                                                   |                                                 |    |    |      |    |
| 9                                                | <u>Sacramento Kings</u>         | 27 | 55 | .329 | 35 | 9                                                 | <u>Washington Wizards</u>                       | 42 | 40 | .512 | 20 |
| 10                                               | <u>Dallas Mavericks</u>         | 20 | 62 | .244 | 42 | 10                                                | <u>Orlando Magic</u>                            | 41 | 41 | .500 | 21 |
| 11                                               | <u>Vancouver Grizzlies</u>      | 19 | 63 | .232 | 43 | 11                                                | <u>Detroit Pistons</u>                          | 37 | 45 | .451 | 25 |
| 12                                               | <u>Golden State Warriors</u>    | 19 | 63 | .232 | 43 | 12                                                | <u>Boston Celtics</u>                           | 36 | 46 | .439 | 26 |
| 13                                               | <u>Los Angeles Clippers</u>     | 17 | 65 | .207 | 45 | 13                                                | <u>Milwaukee Bucks</u>                          | 36 | 46 | .439 | 26 |
| 14                                               | <u>Denver Nuggets</u>           | 11 | 71 | .134 | 51 | 14                                                | <u>Philadelphia 76ers</u>                       | 31 | 51 | .378 | 31 |
|                                                  |                                 |    |    |      |    | 15                                                | <u>Toronto Raptors</u>                          | 16 | 66 | .195 | 46 |
| First seed in the West, best league record       |                                 |    |    |      |    | First seed in the East, second-best league record |                                                 |    |    |      |    |
| Defeated the (8) <u>Houston Rockets</u> , 3–2    |                                 |    |    |      |    | First round                                       | Defeated the (8) <u>New Jersey Nets</u> , 3–0   |    |    |      |    |
| Defeated the (5) <u>San Antonio Spurs</u> , 4–1  |                                 |    |    |      |    | Conference semifinals                             | Defeated the (4) <u>Charlotte Hornets</u> , 4–1 |    |    |      |    |
| Defeated the (3) <u>Los Angeles Lakers</u> , 4–0 |                                 |    |    |      |    | Conference finals                                 | Defeated the (3) <u>Indiana Pacers</u> , 4–3    |    |    |      |    |

### Regular season series

The Utah Jazz won both games in the regular season series:

January 25, 1998

**Utah Jazz** 101, Chicago Bulls 94

United Center, Chicago, Illinois

February 4, 1998

Chicago Bulls 93, **Utah Jazz** 101

Delta Center, Salt Lake City, Utah

## 1998 NBA Finals rosters

| Chicago Bulls                |     |                                |                     |                 |            |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|------------------------------|-----|--------------------------------|---------------------|-----------------|------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1997–98 Chicago Bulls roster |     |                                |                     |                 |            |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| Players                      |     |                                |                     |                 |            | Coaches                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| Pos.                         | No. | Player                         | Height              | Weight          | DOB        | From                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| SF                           | 22  | <a href="#">Keith Booth</a>    | 6 ft 6 in (1.98 m)  | 226 lb (103 kg) | 1974–10–09 | <a href="#">Maryland</a>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| PG                           | 1   | <a href="#">Randy Brown</a>    | 6 ft 2 in (1.88 m)  | 190 lb (86 kg)  | 1968–05–22 | <a href="#">New Mexico State</a>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| SF                           | 30  | <a href="#">Jud Buechler</a>   | 6 ft 6 in (1.98 m)  | 220 lb (100 kg) | 1968–06–19 | <a href="#">Arizona</a>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| SF                           | 24  | <a href="#">Scott Burrell</a>  | 6 ft 7 in (2.01 m)  | 218 lb (99 kg)  | 1971–01–12 | <a href="#">Connecticut</a>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| PG                           | 9   | <a href="#">Ron Harper</a>     | 6 ft 6 in (1.98 m)  | 185 lb (84 kg)  | 1964–01–20 | <a href="#">Miami (OH)</a>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| SG                           | 23  | <a href="#">Michael Jordan</a> | 6 ft 6 in (1.98 m)  | 215 lb (98 kg)  | 1963–02–17 | <a href="#">North Carolina</a>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| PG                           | 25  | <a href="#">Steve Kerr</a>     | 6 ft 3 in (1.91 m)  | 175 lb (79 kg)  | 1965–09–27 | <a href="#">Arizona</a>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| C                            | 53  | <a href="#">Joe Kleine</a>     | 6 ft 11 in (2.11 m) | 255 lb (116 kg) | 1962–01–04 | <a href="#">Arkansas</a>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| SF                           | 7   | <a href="#">Toni Kukoč</a>     | 6 ft 10 in (2.08 m) | 192 lb (87 kg)  | 1968–09–18 | <a href="#">Croatia</a>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|                              |     |                                |                     |                 |            | <b>Head coach</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li><a href="#">Phil Jackson</a></li> </ul> <b>Assistant(s)</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li><a href="#">Bill Cartwright</a></li> <li><a href="#">Frank Hamblen</a></li> <li><a href="#">Jim Rodgers</a></li> <li><a href="#">Tex Winter</a></li> </ul> |
|                              |     |                                |                     |                 |            | <b>Legend</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li><b>(DP)</b> Unsigned draft pick</li> <li><b>(FA)</b> Free agent</li> <li><b>(S)</b> Suspended</li> <li><b>+</b> Injured</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                |
|                              |     |                                |                     |                 |            | Roster ( <a href="https://www.basketball-reference.com/teams/CHI/1998.html">https://www.basketball-reference.com/teams/CHI/1998.html</a> )                                                                                                                                                                             |

| Pos. ♦    | No. ♦ | Player ♦               | Height ♦           | Weight ♦        | DOB ♦      | From ♦                   |
|-----------|-------|------------------------|--------------------|-----------------|------------|--------------------------|
| <u>PG</u> | 5     | <u>Rusty LaRue</u>     | 6 ft 2 in (1.88 m) | 210 lb (95 kg)  | 1973–12–10 | <u>Wake Forest</u>       |
| <u>C</u>  | 13    | <u>Luc Longley</u>     | 7 ft 2 in (2.18 m) | 265 lb (120 kg) | 1969–01–19 | <u>New Mexico</u>        |
| <u>SF</u> | 33    | <u>Scottie Pippen</u>  | 6 ft 8 in (2.03 m) | 220 lb (100 kg) | 1965–09–25 | <u>Central Arkansas</u>  |
| <u>PF</u> | 91    | <u>Dennis Rodman</u>   | 6 ft 8 in (2.03 m) | 210 lb (95 kg)  | 1961–05–13 | <u>SE Oklahoma State</u> |
| <u>C</u>  | 34    | <u>Bill Wennington</u> | 7 ft 0 in (2.13 m) | 245 lb (111 kg) | 1963–04–26 | <u>St. John's</u>        |

## Utah Jazz

| 1997–98 Utah Jazz roster |       |                         |                     |                 |            |                          |                        |
|--------------------------|-------|-------------------------|---------------------|-----------------|------------|--------------------------|------------------------|
| Players                  |       |                         |                     |                 |            | Coaches                  |                        |
| Pos. ♦                   | No. ♦ | Player ♦                | Height ♦            | Weight ♦        | DOB ♦      | From ♦                   | Head coach             |
| <u>SG</u>                | 40    | <u>Shandon Anderson</u> | 6 ft 6 in (1.98 m)  | 208 lb (94 kg)  | 1973–12–31 | <u>Georgia</u>           | ▪ <u>Jerry Sloan</u>   |
| <u>PF</u>                | 55    | <u>Antoine Carr</u>     | 6 ft 9 in (2.06 m)  | 225 lb (102 kg) | 1961–07–23 | <u>Wichita State</u>     | <b>Assistant(s)</b>    |
| <u>PG</u>                | 10    | <u>Howard Eisley</u>    | 6 ft 2 in (1.88 m)  | 177 lb (80 kg)  | 1972–12–04 | <u>Boston College</u>    | ▪ <u>Gordon Chiesa</u> |
| <u>C</u>                 | 44    | <u>Greg Foster</u>      | 6 ft 11 in (2.11 m) | 240 lb (109 kg) | 1968–10–03 | <u>UTEP</u>              | ▪ <u>David Fredman</u> |
| <u>SG</u>                | 14    | <u>Jeff Hornacek</u>    | 6 ft 3 in (1.91 m)  | 190 lb (86 kg)  | 1963–05–03 | <u>Iowa State</u>        | ▪ <u>Phil Johnson</u>  |
| <u>PG</u>                | 25    | <u>Troy Hudson</u>      | 6 ft 1 in (1.85 m)  | 170 lb (77 kg)  | 1976–03–13 | <u>Southern Illinois</u> | ▪ <u>Kenny Natt</u>    |
| <u>SF</u>                | 31    | <u>Adam Keefe</u>       | 6 ft 9 in (2.06 m)  | 230 lb (104 kg) | 1970–02–22 | <u>Stanford</u>          |                        |
| <u>PF</u>                | 32    | <u>Karl Malone</u>      | 6 ft 9 in (2.06 m)  | 250 lb (113 kg) | 1963–07–24 | <u>Louisiana Tech</u>    |                        |
| <u>SF</u>                | 34    | <u>Chris Morris</u>     | 6 ft 8 in (2.03 m)  | 210 lb (95 kg)  | 1966–01–20 | <u>Auburn</u>            |                        |
| <u>C</u>                 | 00    | <u>Greg Ostertag</u>    | 7 ft 2 in (2.18 m)  | 280 lb (127 kg) | 1973–03–06 | <u>Kansas</u>            |                        |
| <u>SF</u>                | 3     | <u>Bryon Russell</u>    | 6 ft 7 in (2.01 m)  | 225 lb (102 kg) | 1970–12–31 | <u>Long Beach State</u>  |                        |
| <u>PG</u>                | 12    | <u>John Stockton</u>    | 6 ft 1 in (1.85 m)  | 170 lb (77 kg)  | 1962–03–26 | <u>Gonzaga</u>           |                        |
| <u>PG</u>                | 11    | <u>Jacque Vaughn</u>    | 6 ft 1 in (1.85 m)  | 190 lb (86 kg)  | 1975–02–11 | <u>Kansas</u>            |                        |

### Legend

- **(DP)** Unsigned draft pick
- **(FA)** Free agent
- **(S)** Suspended
- **+** Injured

Roster (<https://www.basketball-reference.com/teams/UTA/1998.html>)

## Series summary

| Game   | Date    | Road team            | Result           | Home team            |
|--------|---------|----------------------|------------------|----------------------|
| Game 1 | June 3  | Chicago Bulls        | 85–88 (OT) (0–1) | <b>Utah Jazz</b>     |
| Game 2 | June 5  | <b>Chicago Bulls</b> | 93–88 (1–1)      | Utah Jazz            |
| Game 3 | June 7  | Utah Jazz            | 54–96 (1–2)      | <b>Chicago Bulls</b> |
| Game 4 | June 10 | Utah Jazz            | 82–86 (1–3)      | <b>Chicago Bulls</b> |
| Game 5 | June 12 | <b>Utah Jazz</b>     | 83–81 (2–3)      | Chicago Bulls        |
| Game 6 | June 14 | <b>Chicago Bulls</b> | 87–86 (4–2)      | Utah Jazz            |

Bulls win the series 4–2.

## Game 1

|        |                                                                                                                                                              |                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                |            |
|--------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| June 3 | Boxscore ( <a href="https://www.basketball-reference.com/boxscores/199806030UTA.html">https://www.basketball-reference.com/boxscores/199806030UTA.html</a> ) | Chicago Bulls 85, <b>Utah Jazz</b> 88 (OT)<br><b>Scoring by quarter:</b> 17–17, 23–28, 19–22, 20–12, <b>Overtime:</b> 6–9<br><b>Pts:</b> Michael Jordan 33<br><b>Rebs:</b> Pippen, Longley 8<br><b>Asts:</b> Steve Kerr 5 | Delta Center, Salt Lake City, Utah<br><b>Attendance:</b> 19,911<br><b>Referees:</b><br>▪ Ron Garretson<br>▪ Steve Javie<br>▪ Bennett Salvatore | <u>NBC</u> |
|        |                                                                                                                                                              | <b>Pts:</b> John Stockton 24<br><b>Rebs:</b> Karl Malone 14<br><b>Asts:</b> John Stockton 8<br><b>Utah leads the series, 1–0</b>                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                |            |

## Game 2

|        |                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                                                            |     |
|--------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| June 5 | Boxscore<br>( <a href="https://www.basketball-reference.com/boxscores/199806050UTA.html">https://www.basketball-reference.com/boxscores/199806050UTA.html</a> ) | <b>Chicago Bulls</b> 93, <b>Utah Jazz</b> 88<br><b>Scoring by quarter:</b> 23–20, 27–26, 20–27, 23–15<br><b>Pts:</b> Michael Jordan 37 <b>Pts:</b> Jeff Hornacek 20<br><b>Rebs:</b> Kukoč, Rodman 9 <b>Rebs:</b> Karl Malone 12<br><b>Asts:</b> Scottie Pippen 4 <b>Asts:</b> John Stockton 7<br><b>Series tied, 1–1</b> | Delta Center, Salt Lake City, Utah<br><b>Attendance:</b> 19,911<br><b>Referees:</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Danny Crawford</li><li>Joe Crawford</li><li>Bill Oakes</li></ul> | NBC |
|--------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|

## Game 3

|        |                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                                                        |     |
|--------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| June 7 | Boxscore<br>( <a href="https://www.basketball-reference.com/boxscores/199806070CHI.html">https://www.basketball-reference.com/boxscores/199806070CHI.html</a> ) | <b>Utah Jazz</b> 54, <b>Chicago Bulls</b> 96<br><b>Scoring by quarter:</b> 14–17, 17–32, 14–23, 9–24<br><b>Pts:</b> Karl Malone 22 <b>Pts:</b> Michael Jordan 24<br><b>Rebs:</b> Greg Ostertag 9 <b>Rebs:</b> Ron Harper 10<br><b>Asts:</b> John Stockton 7 <b>Asts:</b> Ron Harper 7<br><b>Chicago leads series, 2–1</b> | United Center, Chicago, Illinois<br><b>Attendance:</b> 23,844<br><b>Referees:</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Dick Bavetta</li><li>Hue Hollins</li><li>Ronnie Nunn</li></ul> | NBC |
|--------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|

## Game 4

|         |                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                    |     |
|---------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| June 10 | Boxscore<br>( <a href="https://www.basketball-reference.com/boxscores/199806100CHI.html">https://www.basketball-reference.com/boxscores/199806100CHI.html</a> ) | <b>Utah Jazz</b> 82, <b>Chicago Bulls</b> 86<br><b>Scoring by quarter:</b> 19–21, 18–18, 20–22, 25–25<br><b>Pts:</b> Karl Malone 21 <b>Pts:</b> Michael Jordan 34<br><b>Rebs:</b> Karl Malone 14 <b>Rebs:</b> Dennis Rodman 14<br><b>Asts:</b> John Stockton 13 <b>Asts:</b> Scottie Pippen 5<br><b>Chicago leads series, 3–1</b> | United Center, Chicago, Illinois<br><b>Attendance:</b> 23,844<br><b>Referees:</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Hugh Evans</li><li>Steve Javie</li><li>Jack Nies</li></ul> | NBC |
|---------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|

Crowd: 24,000 at United Center (sellout)

## Game 5

|         |                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |                                                                                                                                                                                             |     |
|---------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| June 12 | Boxscore<br>( <a href="https://www.basketball-reference.com/boxscores/199806120CHI.html">https://www.basketball-reference.com/boxscores/199806120CHI.html</a> ) | <b>Utah Jazz</b> 83, <b>Chicago Bulls</b> 81<br><b>Scoring by quarter:</b> 16–18, 14–18, 29–19, 24–26<br><b>Pts:</b> Karl Malone 39 <b>Pts:</b> Toni Kukoč 30<br><b>Rebs:</b> Karl Malone 9 <b>Rebs:</b> Scottie Pippen 11<br><b>Asts:</b> John Stockton 12 <b>Asts:</b> Scottie Pippen 11<br><b>Chicago leads series, 3–2</b> | United Center, Chicago, Illinois<br><b>Attendance:</b> 23,844<br><b>Referees:</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Joe Crawford</li><li>Bill Oakes</li><li>Bennett Salvatore</li></ul> | NBC |
|---------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|

To date, this is the most recent NBA Finals game played in Chicago.

## Game 6

|         |                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                             |     |
|---------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| June 14 | Boxscore<br>( <a href="https://www.basketball-reference.com/boxscores/199806140UTA.html">https://www.basketball-reference.com/boxscores/199806140UTA.html</a> ) | <b>Chicago Bulls</b> 87, <b>Utah Jazz</b> 86<br><b>Scoring by quarter:</b> 22–25, 23–24, 16–17, 26–20<br><b>Pts:</b> Michael Jordan 45 <b>Pts:</b> Karl Malone 31<br><b>Rebs:</b> Dennis Rodman 8 <b>Rebs:</b> Karl Malone 11<br><b>Asts:</b> Kukoč, Pippen 4 <b>Asts:</b> Karl Malone 7<br><b>Chicago wins NBA Finals, 4–2</b> | Delta Center, Salt Lake City, Utah<br><b>Attendance:</b> 19,911<br><b>Referees:</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Dick Bavetta</li><li>Danny Crawford</li><li>Hue Hollins</li></ul> | NBC |
|---------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|

To date, this is the most recent NBA Finals game played in Salt Lake City.

### External videos

 Full game broadcast by NBC (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=92fLApYaCGI>) on YouTube

## Game summaries

### Games 1 and 2

Unlike the 1997 Finals, the Jazz and Bulls entered this series as equals. The Jazz had won both regular season meetings with the Bulls, and many analysts predicted a hard-fought seven-game series. The two teams entered the Finals on completely different notes; the Jazz uneventfully swept the Los Angeles Lakers in the Western Conference finals and had a total of ten days' rest before the Finals began. The Bulls, meanwhile, endured a hard-fought series against a resurgent Indiana Pacers team helmed by Larry Bird (in his first year as head coach). They would need all seven games to get past the Pacers and would have only two days' rest before having to travel to Utah. Predictions of a Jazz championship were strengthened with their 88–85 Game 1 victory in overtime in Utah, with Scottie Pippen just missing a 3-pointer at the buzzer. True to form, the Bulls tied the series in Game 2 while putting together a huge fourth-

quarter run to silence the Delta Center and holding on to win 93–88, finally securing their first victory against Utah all season. Karl Malone shot very poorly in the first two games of the series with some misses including one layup in Game 2 that hit the underside of the rim.

### Games 3–5

The Finals moved to Chicago with control of the series at stake in Game 3. In a 96–54 loss, the Jazz set the record for the 42 point loss in Finals history and were hammered by the media for the score, as well as the lowest number of points scored in any NBA game (since eclipsed by a score of 49 from the Bulls on April 10, 1999) since the inception of the shot clock. Every player on the Bulls roster scored at least once, with the Bulls' last-remaining scoreless player, backup center Bill Wennington, nailing his bucket with only 5.2 seconds remaining in the game.<sup>[3]</sup>

Chicago won Game 4 in a close game, 86–82, and Utah took Game 5 83–81 despite nearly blowing a seven-point lead in the last two minutes. Karl Malone had his best game of the series with 39 points, while Antoine Carr made all five of his field goal attempts. The series returned to Utah with the Bulls leading 3–2.

### Game 6 - "The Last Shot"

As they arrived at the Delta Center for Game 6, things didn't look good for the Bulls. Scottie Pippen, whose back was already injured going into the game, aggravated his injury when he dunked the opening basket of the game. He scored only 8 points the whole game. To keep pace with Utah, the Bulls were forced to rely almost entirely on Michael Jordan, who scored 23 points in the first half. Emotions ran high at the Delta Center when the Jazz suffered a critical shot clock violation in the second quarter. Referee Dick Bavetta ruled that Howard Eisley did not get a successful 3-point shot off in time, although TV replays showed that the ball was out of Eisley's hands just before the shot clock hit zero. Later in the fourth quarter, Jordan's two free throws tied the game with only a minute left. The Jazz received some relief as John Stockton hit a three-pointer with 41.9 seconds left to give Utah an 86–83 lead and sent the Delta Center into a frenzy.

After Jordan made a layup to make it 86–85, the Bulls needed to stop the Jazz from scoring again. When John Stockton passed the ball to Karl Malone, Jordan stole the ball away and dribbled down the court. Guarding him was Bryon Russell, one of the Jazz's best defenders. With 10 seconds remaining, Jordan started to dribble right, then crossed over to his left, possibly pushing off on Russell as he did so.<sup>[4]</sup> Now wide open, Jordan buried a 20-foot jumper to give the Bulls an 87-86 lead with 5.2 seconds remaining.<sup>[5][6][7]</sup> After a time-out, Stockton missed a potential game-winning 3-pointer, giving the Bulls their sixth NBA title in eight years. Jordan, who scored 45 points, and whose game-winning shot has been immortalized around the world, was named Finals MVP for the sixth time.

## Player statistics

| Legend     |                       |            |                               |            |                       |
|------------|-----------------------|------------|-------------------------------|------------|-----------------------|
| <b>GP</b>  | Games played          | <b>GS</b>  | Games started                 | <b>MPG</b> | Minutes per game      |
| <b>FG%</b> | Field-goal percentage | <b>3P%</b> | 3-point field-goal percentage | <b>FT%</b> | Free-throw percentage |
| <b>RPG</b> | Rebounds per game     | <b>APG</b> | Assists per game              | <b>SPG</b> | Steals per game       |
| <b>BPG</b> | Blocks per game       | <b>PPG</b> | Points per game               |            |                       |

| Chicago Bulls statistics |    |    |             |             |             |              |            |            |            |            |             |
|--------------------------|----|----|-------------|-------------|-------------|--------------|------------|------------|------------|------------|-------------|
| Player                   | GP | GS | MPG         | FG%         | 3P%         | FT%          | RPG        | APG        | SPG        | BPG        | PPG         |
| <u>Randy Brown</u>       | 2  | 0  | 3.5         | .333        | .000        | .000         | 1.0        | 0.0        | 0.5        | 0.0        | 1.0         |
| <u>Jud Buechler</u>      | 6  | 0  | 5.2         | <b>.600</b> | <b>.667</b> | .000         | 0.3        | 0.3        | 0.2        | 0.2        | 1.3         |
| <u>Scott Burrell</u>     | 6  | 0  | 14.0        | .409        | .250        | .667         | 2.5        | 0.0        | 1.2        | 0.0        | 3.5         |
| <u>Ron Harper</u>        | 6  | 6  | 28.7        | .364        | .167        | .583         | 4.5        | 2.8        | 1.5        | 0.7        | 5.3         |
| <u>Michael Jordan</u>    | 6  | 6  | <b>41.7</b> | .427        | .308        | .814         | 4.0        | 2.3        | <b>1.8</b> | 0.7        | <b>33.5</b> |
| <u>Steve Kerr</u>        | 6  | 0  | 20.7        | .350        | .385        | <b>1.000</b> | 0.3        | 2.5        | 0.3        | 0.0        | 3.8         |
| <u>Toni Kukoč</u>        | 6  | 6  | 37.0        | .500        | .304        | .615         | 4.7        | 2.7        | 1.2        | 0.7        | 15.2        |
| <u>Luc Longley</u>       | 6  | 6  | 21.7        | .444        | .000        | .750         | 4.8        | 1.5        | 0.8        | <b>0.8</b> | 5.0         |
| <u>Scottie Pippen</u>    | 6  | 6  | 39.5        | .410        | .231        | .833         | 6.8        | <b>4.8</b> | 1.7        | <b>0.8</b> | 15.7        |
| <u>Dennis Rodman</u>     | 6  | 0  | 30.5        | .462        | .000        | .667         | <b>8.3</b> | 1.0        | 1.2        | 0.3        | 3.3         |
| <u>Bill Wennington</u>   | 3  | 0  | 4.3         | .400        | .000        | .000         | 1.0        | 0.3        | 0.0        | 0.3        | 1.3         |

| Utah Jazz statistics    |    |    |             |             |             |              |             |            |            |            |             |
|-------------------------|----|----|-------------|-------------|-------------|--------------|-------------|------------|------------|------------|-------------|
| Player                  | GP | GS | MPG         | FG%         | 3P%         | FT%          | RPG         | APG        | SPG        | BPG        | PPG         |
| <u>Shandon Anderson</u> | 6  | 0  | 21.0        | .500        | <b>.333</b> | .818         | 2.7         | 0.3        | 0.2        | 0.2        | 7.3         |
| <u>Antoine Carr</u>     | 6  | 0  | 14.3        | .500        | .000        | .750         | 2.0         | 0.0        | 0.0        | 0.2        | 4.2         |
| <u>Howard Easley</u>    | 6  | 0  | 17.5        | .375        | .143        | <b>1.000</b> | 2.0         | 3.8        | 0.3        | 0.2        | 4.7         |
| <u>Greg Foster</u>      | 6  | 2  | 10.5        | .267        | .000        | .000         | 2.3         | 0.0        | 0.2        | 0.3        | 1.3         |
| <u>Jeff Hornacek</u>    | 6  | 6  | 34.2        | .411        | <b>.333</b> | .833         | 2.7         | 2.7        | 0.8        | 0.2        | 10.7        |
| <u>Adam Keefe</u>       | 5  | 3  | 12.0        | .429        | .000        | .500         | 3.4         | 0.2        | 0.4        | 0.0        | 2.8         |
| <u>Karl Malone</u>      | 6  | 6  | <b>40.5</b> | <b>.504</b> | .000        | .789         | <b>10.5</b> | 3.8        | 1.0        | <b>1.2</b> | <b>25.0</b> |
| <u>Chris Morris</u>     | 6  | 0  | 17.5        | .393        | .000        | .667         | 2.5         | 0.5        | 0.3        | 0.2        | 4.3         |
| <u>Greg Ostertag</u>    | 5  | 1  | 11.0        | .417        | .000        | <b>1.000</b> | 3.2         | 0.0        | 0.0        | 0.2        | 2.2         |
| <u>Bryon Russell</u>    | 6  | 6  | 36.0        | .409        | .286        | .688         | 5.0         | 1.3        | 1.2        | 0.2        | 8.8         |
| <u>John Stockton</u>    | 6  | 6  | 32.3        | .490        | .222        | .727         | 2.5         | <b>8.7</b> | <b>2.0</b> | 0.0        | 9.7         |
| <u>Jacque Vaughn</u>    | 1  | 0  | 7.0         | .000        | .000        | .000         | 2.0         | 0.0        | 0.0        | 0.0        | 0.0         |

## Media coverage

The Finals were televised in the United States by NBC (including for the second straight year WMAQ-TV in Chicago and KSL-TV in Salt Lake City), with Bob Costas on play-by-play and Doug Collins and Isiah Thomas serving as color analysts. Hannah Storm hosted the pre-game show, assisted by Bill Walton, John Salley and Peter Vecsey, and Ahmad Rashad and Jim Gray reported from the sidelines. This was the first time since NBC took over the broadcasting rights to the NBA Finals in 1991 that Marv Albert was not the play by play commentator. He was fired from NBC on September 25, 1997, for sexually assaulting a woman.

## Legacy and Aftermath

World Championship Wrestling would capitalize on the animosity following the Finals between Rodman and Malone, as on July 12, 1998, Rodman and Hollywood Hogan would defeat Malone and Diamond Dallas Page in a tag team match at Bash at the Beach.<sup>[8]</sup>

As of the 2024–25 season, this series remains the last Finals appearances for both the Bulls and Jazz. After the season, the Bulls dynasty broke up. Without its key personnel, the Bulls missed the playoffs in the lockout-shortened 1999 season, winning just 13 of 50 games. The Bulls would not make the postseason again until 2005. Both teams have made just one Conference Finals appearance since this Finals, with the Jazz qualifying in 2007, losing to the San Antonio Spurs, and the Bulls qualifying in 2011 under MVP Derrick Rose, losing to the Miami Heat.

Phil Jackson declined an offer from the team president to coach another season.<sup>[9]</sup> He would come back as head coach of the Los Angeles Lakers in 1999, winning five NBA titles in two separate stints with the team before retiring in 2011. This would give Jackson 11 NBA Titles, the most for a coach in the history of the four major American sports leagues. Ron Harper followed Jackson to the Lakers and won championships during his final two seasons in 2000 and 2001 (other Bulls dynasty alum were on those teams, such as John Salley and Horace Grant).

On January 13, 1999, Michael Jordan announced his retirement for the second time;<sup>[10]</sup> he would come out of retirement for the second and final time in 2001 with the Washington Wizards and played two seasons with the team. However, neither season ended with a playoff appearance.<sup>[11][12]</sup> Scottie Pippen was traded to the Houston Rockets during the offseason and played his last season (2003–04) with the Bulls and also played for the Portland Trail Blazers. Dennis Rodman, released by the Bulls in the offseason, signed with the Lakers mid-season, playing only 23 games before being released. In January 1999, the Bulls re-signed Steve Kerr and traded him to the San Antonio Spurs,<sup>[13]</sup> where he would win two more championships in 1999 and 2003, his last year in the NBA.<sup>[14]</sup> After turning down Phil Jackson's offer to coach the New York Knicks (Jackson was the president of basketball operations of the team),<sup>[15][16]</sup> Kerr would go on to win four championships as head coach of the Golden State Warriors in 2015, 2017, 2018, and 2022.<sup>[17]</sup> Both Pippen and Kerr played opposite of former coach Phil Jackson's Lakers in multiple playoff series in the early 2000s.<sup>[18][19][20]</sup>

John Stockton and Karl Malone led the Jazz to playoff appearances each season through 2003, however each season featured a loss in the first or second round. During the 2003 off-season, Stockton retired and Malone joined the Los Angeles Lakers. Malone returned to the NBA Finals in 2004 where he would lose to the Detroit Pistons in 5 games. Jerry Sloan would coach the Jazz until his retirement in 2011.

The Jazz were the last non California or Texas Western Conference NBA Finals team until the 2012 Oklahoma City Thunder, a span of 13 years.

Michael Jordan's 1998 NBA Finals ‘The Last Dance’ game worn jersey sold for \$10,091,000 in 2022, a record for an NBA jersey.<sup>[21]</sup>



## In Popular Culture

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In 2020, *The Last Dance* was documentary miniseries co-produced by [ESPN Films](#) and [Netflix](#); a series that revolved around Michael Jordan's career, with particular focus on the 1997–98 season, his final season with the Chicago Bulls. The series was met with critical acclaim, with praise for its directing and editing, and also for the timing of the release - during the initial weeks of [quarantine](#) during the [COVID-19 pandemic](#) when viewers were struggling to find entertainment.<sup>[22][23]</sup> *The Last Dance* won the [Primetime Emmy Award for Outstanding Documentary or Nonfiction Series](#) at the [72nd Primetime Emmy Awards](#).

Additionally, a cinematic presentation of [Game 6](#) was released by ESPN after the final episode.<sup>[24][25]</sup>

## See also

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- 1998 NBA playoffs
- The Last Shot
- The Last Dance

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